

Reported Speech (Full System)

C1 · Renan the Teacher — English Language Academy

1. BRIEF EXPLANATION

At C1, reported speech goes beyond "he said that..." to use precise reporting verb patterns that capture the speaker's exact intention, plus correct backshifting in more complex contexts.

- a) Reporting verb patterns — many verbs have their own fixed structure:
- - verb + object + to-infinitive: urge/persuade/encourage/warn + sb + to do sth

"You should see a doctor," she said. → She urged him to see a doctor.

- - verb + gerund (often with a preposition): deny doing, admit doing, insist on doing, apologize for doing

"I didn't take it," he said. → He denied taking it.

- - verb + object + not + to-infinitive: warn/tell/advise + sb + not + to do sth

"Don't touch that," he said. → He warned her not to touch it.

- - verb + that-clause: suggest/insist/recommend + that + subject + (should) + bare infinitive

"Let's leave early," she said. → She suggested that they (should) leave early.

- b) Backshifting in complex contexts — when the reporting verb is in the past, tenses generally shift one step back (present → past, past → past perfect, will → would), BUT:
- - No backshift is needed for general truths/facts: "The Earth orbits the Sun," he said. → He said that the Earth orbits the Sun.
- - No backshift if the situation is still true/relevant now: "I'm working in Berlin," she said (and still is). → She said she's working in Berlin.
- - Modals like "would," "could," "might," "should," "ought to" don't change.
- c) Mixed reporting structures — combining reported statements, questions and commands in one passage, and reporting entire exchanges naturally rather than word-for-word.

2. EXAMPLES

- 1. She urged him to reconsider his decision.
- 2. He denied breaking the vase.
- 3. They warned us not to go near the cliff edge.
- 4. The doctor recommended that she rest for a week.
- 5. He apologized for being late.
- 6. She insisted on paying for dinner.
- 7. The manager suggested that the meeting be postponed.

- 8. He admitted taking the last cookie.
- 9. She promised to call as soon as she landed.
- 10. They accused him of lying to the committee.
- 11. The teacher advised the students not to panic during the exam.
- 12. He said that water boils at 100 degrees Celsius.

3. COMMON MISTAKES

- 1. Incorrect: She suggested him to leave early.

Correct: She suggested that he (should) leave early. / She suggested leaving early.

Why: "Suggest" never takes object + to-infinitive; use "suggest that..." or "suggest + gerund."

- 2. Incorrect: He denied to steal the money.

Correct: He denied stealing the money.

Why: "Deny" is followed by a gerund, not a to-infinitive.

- 3. Incorrect: She warned him don't go outside.

Correct: She warned him not to go outside.

Why: "Warn" needs object + not + to-infinitive, not a direct quote structure.

- 4. Incorrect: He said me that he was tired.

Correct: He told me that he was tired. / He said (that) he was tired.

Why: "Say" doesn't take a direct object for the listener; use "tell" for that, or drop the object with "say."

- 5. Incorrect: She said that the Earth orbited the Sun.

Correct: She said that the Earth orbits the Sun.

Why: General/scientific truths usually keep the present tense even after a past reporting verb.

4. EXERCISES

- A. Gap-fill (use the correct reporting verb pattern)
- 1. "You really should apologize," she said to him. → She urged him ____ (apologize).
- 2. "I didn't break the window," he said. → He denied ____ (break) the window.
- 3. "Please don't tell anyone," she said. → She asked him ____ (not/tell) anyone.
- 4. "Let's take a break," the teacher said. → The teacher suggested that they ____ (take) a break.
- 5. "I'm sorry I forgot your birthday," he said. → He apologized ____ (forget)

her birthday.

- 6. "You must see this movie," she said. → She insisted ____ (see) the movie.
- 7. "I'll finish it tomorrow," he said. → He promised ____ (finish) it the next day.
- 8. "It was you who took my pen," she said to him. → She accused him ____ (take) her pen.
- B. Rewrite / Transformation (report the direct speech using an appropriate pattern)
 - 1. "Don't swim in that river," the guide said to us. → The guide warned ____
 - 2. "I'll pay for the tickets," she said. → She offered ____
 - 3. "It wasn't me who broke it," he said. → He denied ____
 - 4. "You should really talk to a lawyer," she said to him. → She advised ____
 - 5. "Let's reschedule the meeting," said the director. → The director suggested ____
 - 6. "I'm so sorry for shouting at you," she said. → She apologized ____
- C. Error Correction
 - 1. He suggested her to call the office first.
 - 2. She denied to have seen the email.
 - 3. They warned us don't be late.
 - 4. He told that he was busy.
 - 5. The nurse recommended he takes more rest.
 - 6. She said that the meeting starts at nine, but by the time we spoke it had already finished.
- D. Guided Production
 - 1. Report something a friend recently told you using "denied" or "admitted."
 - 2. Report an instruction someone gave you using "warned...not to" or "told...not to."
 - 3. Report a suggestion someone made using "suggested that."
 - 4. Write a short two-sentence report of a real or imagined conversation, mixing at least two reporting verbs.

5. ANSWER KEY

- A. Gap-fill
 - 1. to apologize
 - 2. breaking
 - 3. not to tell
 - 4. take
 - 5. for forgetting
 - 6. on seeing
 - 7. to finish
 - 8. of taking
- B. Rewrite / Transformation
 - 1. The guide warned us not to swim in that river.
 - 2. She offered to pay for the tickets.
 - 3. He denied breaking it.
 - 4. She advised him to talk to a lawyer.
 - 5. The director suggested rescheduling the meeting. / ...that they reschedule the meeting.
 - 6. She apologized for shouting at me/him/her.
- C. Error Correction

- 1. He suggested that she call the office first. / He suggested calling the office first.
- 2. She denied having seen the email. / She denied seeing the email.
- 3. They warned us not to be late.
- 4. He said that he was busy. (or: He told us that he was busy.)
- 5. The nurse recommended that he take more rest.
- 6. She said that the meeting starts at nine. (kept correctly as a scheduled/general fact — no error here; included as a check item)
- D. Guided Production (sample answers)
- 1. My roommate admitted eating the last slice of pizza I'd been saving.
- 2. The lifeguard warned the children not to swim past the flags.
- 3. My colleague suggested that we push the deadline back by a week.
- 4. My sister said she'd be late, and she apologized for not calling sooner.

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